

BIOPSY

xyh tamura

CHARACTERS:

Glioblastoma A tumor removed from a doctor, and contains a doctor's memories at 35. This doctor died before the tumor could be biopsied. The character will have a grotesque white look, which can be prosthetically done or through clothes, or other means.

Meningioma The tumor of a 48 year-old woman who took care of her husband before needing surgery herself. The hospital was slowed down due to COVID lockdowns before this could be fully processed. Yellow themed look.

Hematoma A blood clot from a dead little girl's accident. This does not contain any memories from the patient, only its own. Dark red themed look.

SETTING:

This occurs inside a biopsy room, during the pandemic. As the play progresses, the background will become more and more organic as the tumors sculpt their own hospital with forgotten biological matter.

Scene 1

[An operation theater. Spotlight on Hematoma, who is wearing an oversized white coat. Glioblastoma and Meningioma are backstage, but still audible.]

MENINGIOMA

The air is thick with the memory of old blood and cheap floor wax. The crisp sterile air of the surgery room soon replaces it. The sterilized linen smells freshly baked. As if it were pandesal, but it's linen.

GLIOBLASTOMA

The objective: a shunt installation for a three-year-old. You have been awake for twenty-eight hours. Your socks are damp with sweat. You feel the tremor in your right thumb.

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Scalpel. Ten blade.

HEMATOMA (as NURSE 1)

Scalpel, Doc.

[Hematoma hands the scalpel to itself.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

You focus. The world outside the surgical drape turns into a void. There is no traffic outside. It is just you and this brain, floating in space.

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Magi-incision na ako.

MENINGIOMA

The anaesthesia machine hums gently. Hummmmmmm. There is always a lack of ventilators here, and patients need to be manually ventilated with an ambu bag. But during surgery at least, breathing can be done for us, for certain.

[Hematoma mimes making an incision]

GLIOBLASTOMA

Bifrontal coronal incision. Retract the scalp flap. You see the bone now. White. Silent. Like the mother's face when she first brought in her child.

[Meningioma barges in, pulling out a crumpled piece of paper]

MENINGIOMA

Ito lang po ang kaya namin sa ngayon.

GLIOBLASTOMA

We needed twenty-thousand for the OR fees. Seven-thousand for the anesthesia. Five-thousand for the CT scan. Somehow, we got the politicians' signatures in time, and moved things around. You see the bone now. White. Like a hospital ward.

MENINGIOMA

Like fresh sheet, or fresh palitaw.

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Like the white of the eye.

HEMATOMA (As NURSE 1)

Ano po?

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Ay. Drill.

[Hematoma picks up the drill, and starts miming the drilling procedure]

GLIOBLASTOMA

You are drilling holes at Kocher's point. You are looking for the ventricle. You are searching for the water that is crushing this child's thoughts.

MENINGIOMA

[Mimicking the high-pitched grinding of a drill hitting bone]

Zzzzzzzzzzzzz-t! Zzzzzzzzzzzzz-t!

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Ayun, na drill ko na. Next, Irrigation. Tubig.

HEMATOMA (As NURSE 1)

[washes away any debris from the site]

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Okay, nairrigate na. Shunt going in.

[Hematoma mimes threading a shunt into the brain]

MENINGIOMA

You know the stakes of this: One wrong move and it's a dangerous bleed not easily fixed with the resources we have.

GLIOBLASTOMA

The brain is soft. Friable. Like over-ripe fruit. You feel the heat coming from your own body.

[Hematoma gradually puts the shunt in, with some heavy breathing]

GLIOBLASTOMA

You hold your breath, to keep your hands steady.

[Hematoma stops breathing heavily. A few seconds of silence across the room]

MENINGIOMA

You know the stakes of this: One wrong move and it's a dangerous bleed not easily fixed with the resources we have.

GLIOBLASTOMA

You're waiting for the "pop." That sudden, tiny lack of resistance when the plastic tip finally breaks through into the ventricle; the sea inside the head.

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Nasa ventricle na ako.

MENINGIOMA (Vocalizing a gentle, rhythmic dripping)

Drip... drip... drip..

HEMATOMA (As NURSE 1)

May CSF na, Doc. Clear po. Successful.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Cases like these sometimes give you a high. That you managed to do something difficult. Especially under the circumstances. It's what you imagine an Olympian might feel upon getting a gold medal.

[Hematoma sighs.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

But you don't want to celebrate just yet, until you're out of the OR.

HEMATOMA (As SURGEON)

Suture.

[Hematoma mimes sewing the scalp back together with quick, rhythmic, expert motions.]

MENINGIOMA

The skin is closed, and the plastic tube is hidden under the bone, left to drain the fluid into the abdomen.

GLIOBLASTOMA

You finally walk out of the OR. Half an hour later, you're approached by staff.

[Meningioma comes in as medical staff.]

MENINGIOMA

Nasa recovery na po si Mario G. Doc, regarding po yung shinunt natin kahapon, si Grace M. Inform ko lang po kayo na nag-mortality na. 1:42 AM. Mother was firm with her DNR status.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Your surgery yesterday was just as good as it was today. But here, a perfect surgery is only half the math. Recovery can be unpredictable, and often, patients just don't have enough money to keep going.

[Meningioma walks off stage.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

And then you go back to the office, let the resident mosquitoes feast on your ankles, and wait for the next case.

MENINGIOMA

The operation theater is closed.

Scene 2

[The lights from a spotlight to the whole room lightning of the biopsy room. GLIOBLASTOMA and MENINGIOMA step fully onto the stage.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

Your first time being the surgeon, Hema.

HEMATOMA

How was that? How was I, Glio?

[Hematoma removes the medical coat]

GLIOBLASTOMA

I thought it was good, but typically surgeons are less shaky.

HEMATOMA

Shaky? What do you mean, Glio?

GLIOBLASTOMA

We're surgeons.

[The three of them mime rearranging furniture, cleaning, and building flesh structures on the

stage throughout the scene]

MENINGIOMA

I heard one of them crying in the hallway last week! It's true. Pero for five minutes lang. I think you're missing that. Crying and surging, and crying and surging, Hema.

HEMATOMA

Men, and how do you do that?

MENINGIOMA

I think you just feel it inside and then it becomes something.

HEMATOMA

But... I don't have memories like you two.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Some surgeons aren't very emotional. There were two residents I knew that were like that. They went on case after case.

MENINGIOMA

Some of them really are like that? Behind the scenes?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Some surgeons aren't very emotional, Meni.

HEMATOMA

What's it mean to feel something inside first anyway? Ano yun?

MENINGIOMA

Anyway, it's been three months.

GLIOBLASTOMA

It's been three months since they stopped really coming here so often.

HEMATOMA

They're always in full suits now. It's funny.

GLIOBLASTOMA

And it wasn't like that before.

MENINGIOMA

I listened to the transmission last night. It's locked down.

[Meningioma sinks a body part into a tangle of cables.]

HEMATOMA

They've forgotten about us!! They've forgotten!!

GLIOBLASTOMA

And left us here with all this biomass that we can reshape, Hema. Here among the other samples.

MENINGIOMA

Something is spreading among them.

HEMATOMA

Of course they've forgotten! They gave us a name: tumor! Something inside, but is supposed to be outside! But we were made inside. I was made from blood, pooling and congealing. A betamax.

MENINGIOMA

Something is spreading from one country to another and that's why they're all locked down.

GLIOBLASTOMA

The IV tubes are good plumbing. But can we do better? These three months... putting together trash, wires, tubes...

HEMATOMA

trash, wires, tubes, like a hospital, like a body

MENINGIOMA

like a body, like a building, tell us again, these three months, Glio...

GLIOBLASTOMA

the last thing I remember before waking up. I was a physician's tumor. He's not too old, not too young. He just got established in his practice.

HEMATOMA

trash, wires, tubes, capillaries, nerves!

GLIOBLASTOMA

I grew right in the center of his brain. Feeling the electricity of his synapses. Of course I

grew fast, I'm a Glioblastoma. They took me out.

MENINGIOMA

a body like a hospital like a home

GLIOBLASTOMA

Oh, he had such hopes! Some people he saved, some days, you can't save them all. Prognosis is poor, of course. What about you, Men?

MENINGIOMA

We already know about me.

HEMATOMA

But I think we want to know, Meni, again and again!

MENINGIOMA

I was there when she took care of her husband. He got into a motorcycle accident with another motorcycle. And I had to be there to pump the Ambu bag. Feed him through the feeder. I did it for months, until he was discharged. He made it out, with no problem. But I had to have surgery. They had to remove me!

GLIOBLASTOMA

Of course they had to. Slow, growing at the edges of the brain, a meningioma. Of course they had to.

MENINGIOMA

to remove me, and here I am.

HEMATOMA

I don't have memories like you two. Just darkness, blood.

MENINGIOMA

darkness, blood, now we're here, a hospital, a home, a body, awake, locked down

GLIOBLASTOMA

darkness, blood, hematoma, locked down, for who knows how long, playing out these roles...

HEMATOMA

Everyday I feel more and more of the hospital

MENINGIOMA

more and more, because it feels like we've started to grow, and they haven't noticed

GLIOBLASTOMA

Well, more and more, because our tumor cells have started to tangle with the wires, have started to talk to the fungi and mold trying to decompose us. and the creeping vines outside.

MENINGIOMA

waking up into these roles, is it our choice to be here? waking up into these roles.

GLIOBLASTOMA

just like them, waking up into these roles, building a hospital, a home, a body. by building, building our own organ

HEMATOMA

an organ in a hospital, just like them, learning these roles, for who knows how long. For who knows.

Scene 3

MENINGIOMA

I think we're just about ready for a new scene.

GLIOBLASTOMA

I'll play the patients later.

HEMATOMA

Exciting! Exciting!

MENINGIOMA

Okay. We did our research for this.

[The three take their places as if on a meeting in a table]

MENINGIOMA (as FINANCE DIRECTOR)

We are looking at a 15% across-the-board reduction for the mid-year. Yung PhilHealth deficit is a black hole, tapos yung Universal Health Care mandate, wala pa rin yung funds na inasahan natin. So if we reallocate from capital outlay, we can maybe secure two ventilators. Dalawa.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as FINANCE OFFICER)

We already cut capital outlay last quarter. There is nothing left to cut that isn't already...

(searches) hypothetical.

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

If you cut our stipends again, I'll lose four more seniors to the US or the UK by December. We need a new drill set.

MENINGIOMA (as FINANCE DIRECTOR)

Alam mo na kung ano ang process for that, just request one with justification. Maaapprove din yan.

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

Many of our cases can't wait for procurement. Some of our cases have been waiting for years.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as FINANCE OFFICER, whispering)

Kuha na lang tayo ng endorsement.

HEMATOMA (as ORTHOPEDICS)

Why does surgery always get priority? Orthopedics has backlog. Trauma cases piling up.

HEMATOMA (as OPHTHALMOLOGY)

That's not true. We're all given what we get in time. I'm thankful na yung optha center is starting construction. This sounds kind of competitive!

GLIOBLASTOMA

Just go with it, Hema.

MENINGIOMA

I kind of like it!

HEMATOMA

I'm still getting used to it, Meni! Okay, what's next?

MENINGIOMA (as FINANCE DIRECTOR)

It's my turn. I have a budget cap on personnel spending that is archaic: 45% of total revenue, or we face a COA audit. My job is to prevent the financial collapse of this institution.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as FINANCE OFFICER)

Talaga? You might be more worried about bookkeeping than the fact that our "unemployed" doctors are congregating in urban centers because you won't fund the rural posts.

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

And the guarantee letter system? Patients have to approach their LGUs to get funding for the “charity” ward. What is charitable about that?

MENINGIOMA (ADMIN again, defensive)

We are not discussing guarantee letters here.

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

We are always discussing guarantee letters.

MENINGIOMA (ADMIN)

We are not the national government. We have to be smart in allocating what we have.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as FINANCE OFFICER)

We are allocating what’s left.

MENINGIOMA (as PHONE)

brrrt.. brrrt..

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

Sorry, I have to get this.

[The scene changes as Hematoma leaves the room. Meningioma and Glioblastoma reposition themselves. Glioblastoma goes backstage.]

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

Hello? Yes. Oo. Alam ko na the HMO is declining the claim, but that’s a private case. I’m in the middle of a government ward right now. Hindi. I’ll just tell the family I’ll sign the PhilHealth forms tonight.

MENINGIOMA (as JUNIOR RESIDENT)

Doc, excuse me. Yung patient po sa Bed 14, the motorcycle accident? The lawyer is asking for the medicolegal report for the insurance. And the PhilHealth portal is down again, so I can’t encode the–

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

Usually it comes back up in a few hours. Sorry Ibu, di kita ma tutulungan with these right now. I have three more surgeries and a lecture on medical malpractice at 4 PM. You need to be able to handle this, and this. I have no time for all of these.

[Hematoma hands Meningioma papers, one by one]

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Doc, 32 hours na rin ako naka duty! Tapos kailangan ko pang tapusin yung census. Hindi pa ako naka-

GLIOBLASTOMA

Well, that's what we were thinking, but what really got said was:

HEMATOMA (as CHIEF OF SURGERY)

When you're climbing the ladder, the reality of practice is that nahahanapan mo nang paraan. We all do.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Yes po.

[Hematoma leaves the scene and re-enters]

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

Ibo, hindi pa rin nagpo-post yung labs.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Ganun naman parati, Ibu. Papunta pa ako sa pasyente ko. Motorcycle accident. As usual. Paano yung CT natin kahapon?

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

Pending din.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

So wala tayong kahit ano.

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

Meron.

Dasal.

[Small laugh. They keep walking.]

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Mag-aabroad ako. After nito.

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

Saan?

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Anywhere.

UK, Australia... kahit Middle East.

It's difficult here, sometimes.

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

You'll retake the boards.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Oo. Or... career change! Nakakapagod na. My stipend is three months delayed. My parents are asking me for money.

HEMATOMA

Wait. I think I'm confused.

MENINGIOMA

What's wrong, Hema?

HEMATOMA

Are they doctors or patients?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Doctors.

HEMATOMA

Then why are they also waiting, Glio?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Because they are doctors.

HEMATOMA

But I thought doctors make the waiting happen.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Doctors usually don't want to make the waiting happen.

HEMATOMA

And sometimes the waiting happens to them? Why are they also leaving?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Because they are doctors, Hema.

MENINGIOMA

It seems the hospital does not only lose patients.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Doctors aren't part of the body of the hospital.

HEMATOMA

I'm still confused, Glio, but we can continue.

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

Tapos makikita mo yung batchmates mo... Si... Pred. Nag corporate na lang.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Tapos si Chief. Earlier.

HEMATOMA (as DR. CET)

Ganun talaga. Konti na lang. Kapit ka lang.

[Hematoma walks off, and Glioblastoma enters the scene, playing a patient and their bantay.]

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Good morning po.

GLIOBLASTOMA

That sounds a bit too cold.

MENINGIOMA

That's what some doctors sounded like.

GLIOBLASTOMA

I think there's just been some thought with bedside manner, that's all.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Good morning po!

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY, quickly)

Doc.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Kamusta po yung pakiramdam?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as PATIENT)

Masakit pa rin... dito.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Hindi po siya nakatulog kagabi, Doc.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

May labs na po ba tayo?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Wala pa po.

MENINGIOMA

I think that's too matter-of-factly.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Okay, I'll try again.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Wala pa po... Kasi... hinihintay pa po namin yung mga pirma.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

May nakausap na po ba kayo?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Opo.

MENINGIOMA

Wait.

GLIOBLASTOMA

What is it, Meni?

MENINGIOMA

That "opo" is too short.

GLIOBLASTOMA

It is a short answer.

MENINGIOMA

No, Glio. As Bantay, you waited in three lines before saying that.

GLIOBLASTOMA

I did?

MENINGIOMA

Yes.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Okay, how's this?

...opo.

Barangay...

city hall...

office ng congressman...

MENINGIOMA

That's great, Glio!

GLIOBLASTOMA (as PATIENT, looking at them)

Doc...

Kaya pa ba?

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Hahanap tayo ng paraan. Sa ngayon, kapit lang tayo. Inom lang po kayo ng medications niyo, okay?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as PATIENT, looking at them)

Sige, doc.

[Meningioma leaves the room. Glioblastoma begins dialling on a phone.]

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Hello?

[Hematoma enters the stage.]

HEMATOMA (as SON)

Ma?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Nak. Dito pa rin ako kasama nang tatay mo.

HEMATOMA (as SON)

Ano sabi ng doctor?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Wala pa kaming result sa lab eh. Hinihintay pa natin.

HEMATOMA (as SON)

Anong Hinihintay?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Yung... papeles. May kailangan pang pirma. Para mabayaran ang mga test. Pipila ulit ako bukas ng madaling araw.

HEMATOMA (as SON)

Ma... Hindi pwede mawala si Papa ngayon.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Gising naman siya, nak.

HEMATOMA (as SON)

Ma! Paano kung macoma siya ulit! Siya lang sa atin ang may steady. Co-college pa ako. Sana gumaling na siya.

MENINGIOMA

I think you should try to comfort your son more.

GLIOBLASTOMA

How?

MENINGIOMA

I don't know exactly the words I said, I just know I did that.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Anak, makakahanap din tayo ng trabaho.

HEMATOMA (as SON)

at magkakakotse.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as BANTAY)

Kotse nga. Magkakakotse.

[The call ends. Glioblastoma leaves the stage. Hematoma hands up, and mimes leaving the house, and posting up at a street corner. Meningioma enters the scene as a med student, with a bag, passing by Hematoma. Hematoma eyes Meningioma, and pickpockets her, stealing her phone. Hematoma leaves the stage. Meningioma walks around more, quickly, before stopping at the center of the stage.]

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Nako! yung phone ko! Ay late pa ako!

[Meningioma panics a bit, and opens the door to her class. Hematoma re-enters the stage as a professor/senior doctor.]

HEMATOMA (as PROFESSOR)

Ms. America! You're late. [flatly]

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Sorry po.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Hm, Hema, A bit more commanding.

HEMATOMA

Commanding?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes. Like you own the room.

HEMATOMA

I don't own the room. I'm Hematoma.

GLIOBLASTOMA

In this version, you're the professor.

HEMATOMA

Okay.

HEMATOMA (as PROFESSOR)

Ms. America! You're late! [grandly]

GLIOBLASTOMA

Not theater commanding. Hospital commanding.

MENINGIOMA

Do people really do this, Glio?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Not as much anymore, Meni. But definitely back in my day.

HEMATOMA

Your day, Glio?

GLIOBLASTOMA

His day.

MENINGIOMA

The doctor's day.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Anyway, let's try again.

HEMATOMA (as PROFESSOR)

Ms. America! You're late. [flatly]

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Sorry po.

HEMATOMA (as PROFESSOR)

Since you have the luxury of arriving late, you can lead the grand rounds. Tell the class the exact dosage and contraindications for administering tPA in a hemorrhagic stroke. Go.

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Doc, for hemorrhagic... tPA is... it's contraindicated because...

HEMATOMA (as PROFESSOR)

Because what? You're guessing. Sit down. You know, If this were the hospital... Nevermind. Let's...

[Glioblastoma knocks from backstage]

GLIOBLASTOMA (as HOSPITAL STAFF)

Doc, may emergency po doc. Kailangan po kayo sa ER.

HEMATOMA (as PROFESSOR)

Okay, class. Take home quiz na lang tayo for the rest of the class. I'll see you next week.

[Hematoma leaves the classroom. Meningioma mimes getting up from class, taking her things, saying goodbye to her classmates, and walking through the hallway. Glioblastoma walks across the stage, directly to Hematoma.]

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MOTHER)

O, anak, hindi ka sumasagot ng phone mo!

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Sorry ho, na-low batt po kasi ako eh.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MOTHER)

I brought you some snacks before yung exam mo. Today yun diba?

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Opo.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MOTHER)

Alam mo yung anak nina Tita, lawyer na siya. Yung isa nag abroad din. Sana ikaw ganun rin.

MENINGIOMA (as STUDENT)

Opo, Nay.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MOTHER)

I'm so excited for you to become the first doctor in the family. Do well, ha!

[Glioblastoma exits. Meningioma walks to the exam room, looking up at her classmates]

HEMATOMA (from backstage)

Exam starts in 10 minutes!

[Meningioma sighs, a mimes sneaking in a kodego in her pocket. At the same time, Glioblastoma walks in the stage, on a phone conversation, as the financial officer from earlier.]

GLIOBLASTOMA (as POLITICIAN/FINANCIAL OFFICER)

Ganun kasi. We have to work with what we have sa public health.

Alam mo diba?

Trillion yung nasa flood infrastructure.

Saan na pupunta yun?

Nasa PGH ako ngayon.

Buti kilala ko ang mga doctors dito.

Si Doc Ibu. St. Luke's sana ako, kaso lang dito yung kilala ko.

Stable raw si mama.

Kailangan ko pa rin ng funds.

Yung property natin sa Shaw Boulevard.

Kailangan masunog na yun.

Let's say electric failure.

Para makolekta natin yung insurance.

Oo.

Hindi yan kakalat.

Hindi yan kakalat.

Para maka-renovate na rin tayo.

Ayaw mo nun?

[Meningioma returns, this time as Dr. Ibu.]

GLIOBLASTOMA (as POLITICIAN/FINANCIAL OFFICER)

Ay, Doc!

Tuloy pala yung subpoena sa kaso natin next week.

You're an expert witness, diba?

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Ah, what case was that?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as POLITICIAN/FINANCIAL OFFICER)

Yung may awayan. In BGC.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

BGC?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as POLITICIAN/FINANCIAL OFFICER)

Don't worry Doc, I'll be there. Besides, it's nobody important. People who are important don't really get into crimes like that.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

How else is a doctor supposed to make money around here?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as POLITICIAN/FINANCIAL OFFICER)

Or anyone else, for that matter.

MENINGIOMA (as DR. IBU)

Somehow, all my friends have left. Even those who aren't doctors. Nakakatawa, dito sila nag train tapos aalis lang din.

HEMATOMA

Wait, are we supposed to be saying this?

MENINGIOMA

I think we need to cut.

Scene 4

[The three tumors applaud themselves and step into the stage]

GLIOBLASTOMA

That was new. Wow!

HEMATOMA

Did you like it? Exciting!

MENINGIOMA

I did! I didn't think admin would be so fun to play.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Really? Most of the time, it's really boring.

HEMATOMA

How strange we are, playing these things!

MENINGIOMA

Strange... What do you mean, Hema? By strange?

HEMATOMA

I mean, it's strange, ah, interesting, that we are playing them. We could be doing something else.

GLIOBLASTOMA

We could... We just started to play them. And we did something new.

HEMATOMA

We always do something new!

MENINGIOMA

Do you feel that? Our hospital has expanded to a new room! Mm. Just last night.

GLIOBLASTOMA

We've been caring for it well.

HEMATOMA

Grew it!

MENINGIOMA

Yes. Grow it. But not only like a plant.

HEMATOMA

Like a clot!

GLIOBLASTOMA

No, Hema, clots do not grow like that. And our hospital, it's connected to us, but it's connected to wires, plants, mold.

HEMATOMA

I grew.

GLIOBLASTOMA

You accumulated.

HEMATOMA

I accumulated myself.

MENINGIOMA

I think that sounds like growing.

HEMATOMA

Glioblastoma, you grew too much.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes.

HEMATOMA

Meningioma grew slowly.

MENINGIOMA

Yes.

HEMATOMA

So we all know different kinds.

MENINGIOMA

There! There, Hema. The new room.

HEMATOMA

Hello, new room!

GLIOBLASTOMA

Our own hospital has expanded into a new room in the hospital.

HEMATOMA

We're our own civilization!

MENINGIOMA

Is that enough to be a civilization? When I think of civilization, I think of noise.

HEMATOMA

Oh. Is it? It's been so quiet.

GLIOBLASTOMA

When I think of civilization, I think of silence.

MENINGIOMA

The room, it has metal shelves.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Records room.

MENINGIOMA

Wet cardboard.

HEMATOMA

Rain room.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Records room.

MENINGIOMA

A computer.

HEMATOMA

Computer room.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Records room with a computer. This is where we, or they slept sometimes.

MENINGIOMA

The computer is not on.

HEMATOMA

Sleeping computer room.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Mold.

MENINGIOMA

Mold on paper.

HEMATOMA

Mold reading.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Mold decomposing the paper. It's a document from the 1900s. Is it because of what is left of our memories, that we can somehow feel what this paper says? Is what we feel even accurate?

HEMATOMA

What's accurate?

GLIOBLASTOMA

The difference between life and death. Meningioma, what were you going to say before we cut? I don't have any memories like that.

MENINGIOMA

Oh, I, guess I got way too into the character. I was going to say, ang mga batchmates ko na iba, na nag BPO, they serve outside clients din. Mga nurses natin, ini-export din natin. So where is the wealth here? Why shouldn't I be thinking of other ways to make money? That's what Dr. Ibu was going to say.

HEMATOMA

That doesn't sound like the scene anymore, at all! I think the mold is speaking for you, or the internet.

GLIOBLASTOMA

The government is still paying off IMF debt from the Marcos Regime after all. For the loans of this country, and even after that during the Asian Financial Crisis.

HEMATOMA

Oh, I see, I think we can read the internet now through the wires.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Hm, and the IMF of course has conditions. Like fiscal austerity, which cuts public spending.

MENINGIOMA

We still have to live, like everyone else.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Did you know that Americans built a nursing school here, among the earliest structures of the hospital?

HEMATOMA

This place was made! This place...

GLIOBLASTOMA

was made up! Made up for something. Many things. It was made up!

MENINGIOMA

Made up the way we make our hospital!

HEMATOMA

We become something, and we can go. Is that where our aspirations come from? Is that why we want to be something at all?

MENINGIOMA

Oh, I think, I think we should ask the hospital.

HEMATOMA

Hospital! Are you the reason why we want to be anything at all?

GLIOBLASTOMA

To be a doctor. It doesn't answer because it is a hospital.

MENINGIOMA

Hospitals answer all the time.

HEMATOMA

With bills.

MENINGIOMA

With alarms.

GLIOBLASTOMA

With lab results.

HEMATOMA

With no lab results.

MENINGIOMA

With waiting.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Does the doctor exist because the hospital exists or is it the other way around? Tell me, hospital!

HEMATOMA

Oh, I found something! A paper!

MENINGIOMA

What does it say?

HEMATOMA

It's shy.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Paper is not shy.

HEMATOMA

Do you want to look at it first, Meni?

MENINGIOMA

Oh, I see see, It's a story about rain.

HEMATOMA

There's this girl who fell into a grave site.

MENINGIOMA

Of course we wanted to save her!

GLIOBLASTOMA

But sometimes a surgery may not even help.

HEMATOMA

She just wanted to play!

MENINGIOMA

But why do they live in the graveyard? The rocks can get slippery when it rains.

GLIOBLASTOMA

There was a fire that displaced them, I heard.

HEMATOMA

We're building something new.

MENINGIOMA

Oh, but I love the flowers.

GLIOBLASTOMA

There's no reason to biopsy a hematoma from somebody whose cause of death we already know.

HEMATOMA

But I know it! I am from this girl. I also just want to play. I want to choose my role.

MENINGIOMA

We're born into it and choose it.

GLIOBLASTOMA:

born into it and choose it. Do we choose it? I was good at order.

HEMATOMA

You are good at doctor.

GLIOBLASTOMA

I was a doctor.

HEMATOMA

Glio. You're a Glioblastoma. We're tumors!

GLIOBLASTOMA

I remember being one.

MENINGIOMA

Glioblastoma.

GLIOBLASTOMA

I remember the incisions, the rounds, the conferences, the phone calls, the mortality. I remember the thumb tremor. I remember the socks. I remember exactly how long I had been awake.

HEMATOMA

Twenty-eight hours.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes.

HEMATOMA

That is too many hours.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes.

MENINGIOMA

And before that?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Before what?

MENINGIOMA

Before the doctor was doctor.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Medical school.

MENINGIOMA

Before that?

GLIOBLASTOMA

College.

MENINGIOMA

Before that?

GLIOBLASTOMA

An ambition.

MENINGIOMA

Whose?

GLIOBLASTOMA

His.

MENINGIOMA

Only his?

GLIOBLASTOMA

Am I, doctor-tumor, tumor that's part of doctor, doctor that's part of hospital. Meni, What are you asking?

MENINGIOMA

I don't know yet.

HEMATOMA

That is okay.

GLIOBLASTOMA

It is not okay.

HEMATOMA

It is a little okay.

GLIOBLASTOMA

If you don't know, you don't act.

MENINGIOMA

Sometimes you act because you don't know.

HEMATOMA

Oh!

GLIOBLASTOMA

That is dangerous.

MENINGIOMA

Yes.

GLIOBLASTOMA

That is how mistakes happen.

MENINGIOMA

Yes.

HEMATOMA

That is how new happens.

GLIOBLASTOMA

A hospital is not a game.

HEMATOMA

But we are playing hospital.

MENINGIOMA

Everyone is playing hospital. A made-up game. Some games you know what happens.

GLIOBLASTOMA

But, in hospital... sometimes the game changes. You don't always know what will happen next.

HEMATOMA

When I, she, held the Ambu bag, I did not know everything. She knew squeeze.

HEMATOMA

Squeeze.

MENINGIOMA

Wait.

HEMATOMA

Wait.

MENINGIOMA

Watch the chest.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Watch oxygen saturation.

MENINGIOMA

Listen for the small change.

HEMATOMA

Small change.

MENINGIOMA

Count.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Every five to six seconds.

MENINGIOMA

But not only count.

HEMATOMA

Not only count.

MENINGIOMA

Because the hand gets tired.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes.

MENINGIOMA

Because the electricity goes out.

HEMATOMA

Yes.

MENINGIOMA

Because someone enters with a different result.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes.

MENINGIOMA

Because the outside gets in.

GLIOBLASTOMA

The hospital is supposed to control outside.

MENINGIOMA

It is.

GLIOBLASTOMA

But we were inside, made outside.

MENINGIOMA

We are tumors!

HEMATOMA

Tumors that act!

GLIOBLASTOMA

Growing a hospital. Becoming, something.

MENINGIOMA

We become because we act.

GLIOBLASTOMA

And we've already switched roles! So what do we do now? What can we do now!

HEMATOMA

We do a new scene!

[The three tumors applaud themselves and rearrange into scene 5]

Scene 5

MENINGIOMA

Doctor.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Doctor.

HEMATOMA

Patience.

[The lighting flickers]

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Okay. Quick meeting lang. Mga... Five minutes.

HEMATOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Yes po!

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Make it three. I have a surgery soon. And my coffee is getting cold. I hate cold coffee.
Nawawala ang Terroir.

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

So. We have a situation.

HEMATOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Emergency po?

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

More like a discrepancy.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Of course.

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

May patient.

May doctor.

May procedure.

But the form...

does not exist.

HEMATOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

So... did the surgery happen?

GLIOBLASTOMA (CONSULTANT)

Depends.

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

On what?

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

On whether we can find the form.

HEMATOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

It's an emergency!

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Saan ang Procurement Form 10-B for the emergency? We cannot have an emergency without the proper requisition.

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

The printer is out of toner. Pero may form for the toner. It's currently pending approval from the Committee on Requisitions of Requisitions.

GLIOBLASTOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Check niyo nga ang website.

HEMATOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Ayun ho. Error 504.

MENINGIOMA (as MEDICAL STAFF)

Kagabi pa yan

GLIOBLASTOMA

Wait, I'll cut something out of our hospital. Maybe that will help. Cutting... cutting... there!

HEMATOMA

Ay!

[The three tumors look at a common spot]

HEMATOMA

Nag upgrade na ang webpage. From Error 504 to 505!

[an invisible guest enters]

GLIOBLASTOMA

Ay hello, Welcome po! Welcome! Thank you for coming!

MENINGIOMA

Dito po kayo sa hospital bed. Special yan. Kung pinipindot to, aakyat siya. Bagong dating! Ito naman. To call for our attention.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes! Yes. Bagong dating. Ano po?

Traffic was terrible? Oo nga po. Kahit walang baha?

HEMATOMA

Walang baha, walang bahala!

MENINGIOMA

So this is our newest model. The Bed 3.0. Smart na po siya.

GLIOBLASTOMA

AI-enabled. Cloud-based. FDA-adjacent.

HEMATOMA

Now, meron din siyang emotional support feature.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Yes, Patok na patok ang mental health sa mga bata.

[Sound of “The bluetooth device is connected successfully”. The Tumors look at each other confused.]

HEMATOMA

Would you like to try the emergency mode?

[They all turn to the invisible guest.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

We highly recommend it.

MENINGIOMA

It's very popular.

HEMATOMA

Trending, actually.

[MENINGIOMA presses something.]

[Alarm Sound. It goes on for a bit too long.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

Ah.

HEMATOMA

Ah.

MENINGIOMA

Hindi na siya namamatay.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Wait, wala pa yung requisition forms.

HEMATOMA

Mamsir... kumusta po kayo?

[The tumors look to the bed.]

MENINGIOMA

...Hindi siya sumasagot.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Check the form.

HEMATOMA

Which form?

GLIOBLASTOMA

The Response Form.

MENINGIOMA

Wala.

HEMATOMA

Ah.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Then there is no response.

[The alarm suddenly stops.]

MENINGIOMA

Ah. Nag-stop din siya. Kailangan natin i-record to. Dito sa 1909 document.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Wait, you'll overwrite the document, Meni!

MENINGIOMA

I'll write it on the edges, Glio.

HEMATOMA

Excuse me, po! The hallway is currently experiencing an unplanned thermal event.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Unplanned?

HEMATOMA

Yes, po.

[The lights become red or orange to indicate a fire.]

GLIOBLASTOMA

We have to alert the whole hospital.

[Meningioma tries to repeatedly press the emergency button on the bed, but nothing happens. Meningioma stops.]

HEMATOMA

Down pa rin po ang website.

MENINGIOMA

Okay. Next agenda item.

GLIOBLASTOMA

Coffee.

HEMATOMA

Ay, malamig na po. Tara, laro na lang tayo ng bola!

GLIOBLASTOMA

Hay, sige. Ito, I'll throw it to you! Sayo na ang bola!

MENINGIOMA

Wait.

[The three tumors look around, or think about what they are doing.]

MENINGIOMA

That's not a fire.

[END PLAY]